

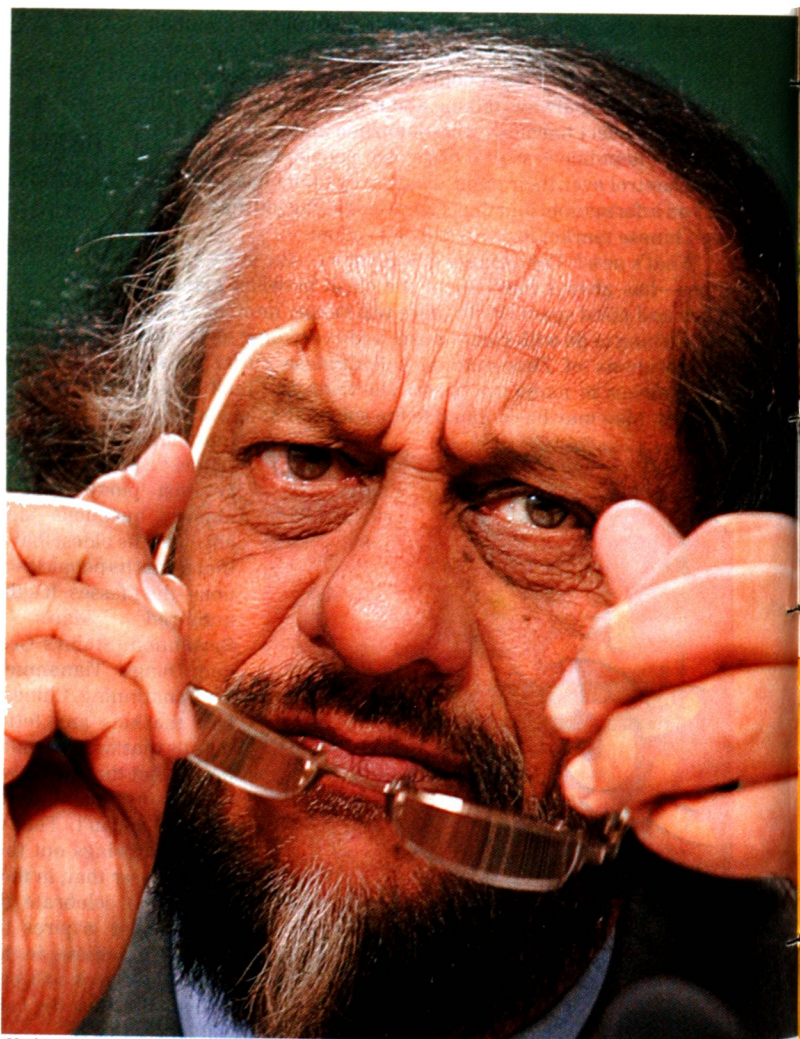
| By Sandeep Unnithan |

A roomful of reporters, whirring TV cameras and popping camera flashes. Dr Rajendra Kumar Pachauri, the world's climate czar, is used to such attention. As chairman of a UN body appointed to study the impact of climate change, which shared the 2007 Nobel Prize with Al Gore, he earned plaudits. But today, on the fourth floor of The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI), which he also heads, it seems the queries are far more pointed and urgent. The angrier flashes and even the frosty Delhi weather outside couldn't seem to cool the rising temperatures in the room. "I have no intentions of resigning from my post. I was elected by acclamation and I have a task to complete," he told the hastily convened press conference. From being the Oracle at the now-stillborn Copenhagen climate summit to defending his appointment as climate chief. All this in little over a month. How did it come to this?

The answer lies in a date. 2035. Thirty years into the future where, the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (ipcc) fourth report rather sensationally predicted in 2007, the Himalayan glaciers could well disappear. The conclusions put a question mark on the fate of mighty rivers like the Indus, Brahmaputra and the Ganges which sustain over 500 million people. Now, it turns out that the date was as real as another Himalayan myth, the Yeti. The ipcc, a group of 2,500 researchers from more than 130 nations, relies on only peer-reviewed and published scientific papers to substantiate its reports. In this case, it had based its claim on a World Wildlife Fund (wwf) report of 2005 based on a 1999 magazine article which quoted a leading Indian glaciologist, Syed Iqbal Hasnain, as saying that at "current rates of shrinkage, the glaciers could be gone in 40 to 50 years". No one knows how the alarmist date of 2035 crept into the crucial report. "Unfortunately, in this case, the well-established ipcc proce-

Feeling the HEAT

The world's climate czar takes a beating over flaws in the IPCC report and charges of conflict of interest



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